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A SRISHTI STUDIOS
PRESENTS

KAGE NO KOE 影の声

CHAPTER 4 THE LAST VOICE



*Some voices never die.
But even the eternal must end.*

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Beyond the seventh mountain,
a gateway awaited —
not to another peak, but
to a world beyond time.

This is it...

There's no
turning back now.

Renjiro and Akari stepped forward,
leaving the world of the living
behind.

On the other side, they found a place unlike anything they had seen — a vast, silent expanse filled with countless figures.



So many...

They were the memories.
Soldiers, families, friends, strangers
— all preserved, yet unable to move on.

Renjiro's heart stopped
when he saw them —
the soldiers of Kirisame.

Kirisame...

I failed you...

Faces he thought were lost
forever. Memories he tried
to bury. They were all here.

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Akari saw faces from her own past — her family, her village, the people she left behind.



Mother...

...Father...

I'm sorry...
I left you...

Their smiles were real,
but they could not reach her.
They were only memories,
trapped in time.

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Renjiro and Akari turned to the Nameless Monk, who stood at the center of this world.

You have seen the result.
Now you must know
the truth.

These are not spirits.
They are memories.
Preserved by the Keepers
centuries ago.

The Monk finally revealed
the complete history.

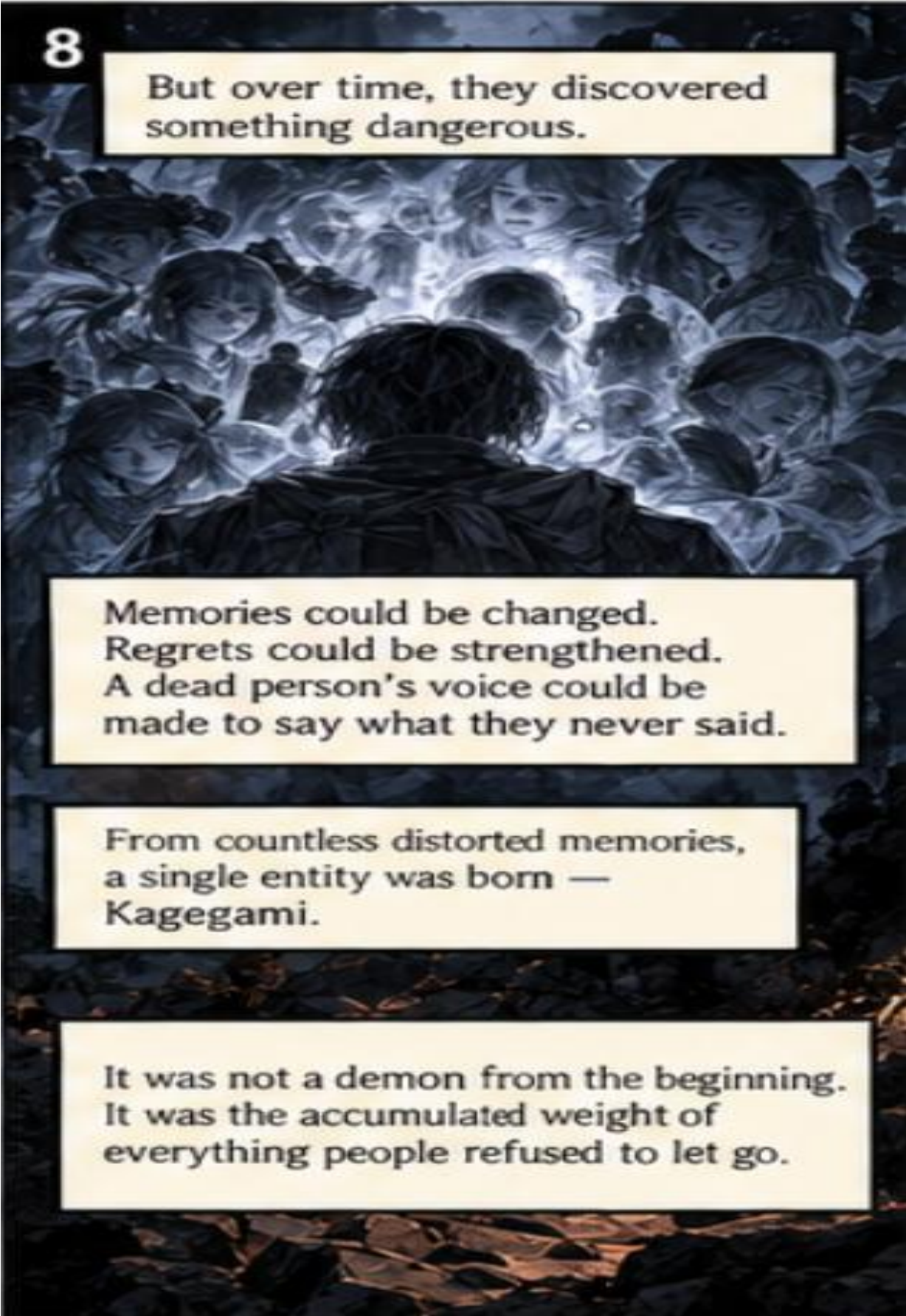


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Long ago, wars destroyed countless lives. People feared that their loved ones would be forgotten.

To protect their memories, an ancient order — the Keepers — discovered the source beneath the seventh mountain.

At first, it was used to preserve voices and memories. A way to keep the dead alive in the hearts of the living.

A dark, atmospheric illustration. In the center, the back of a person's head and shoulders are visible, looking towards a bright, glowing light. Surrounding this light are numerous faces of various ages and expressions, some appearing to be memories or spirits. The overall tone is somber and mysterious.

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But over time, they discovered something dangerous.

Memories could be changed.
Regrets could be strengthened.
A dead person's voice could be made to say what they never said.

From countless distorted memories,
a single entity was born —
Kagegami.

It was not a demon from the beginning.
It was the accumulated weight of
everything people refused to let go.

The Nameless Monk continued.

Kagegami is everything
people refused to let
disappear.

As long as the living cling to
the past, the dead can never
truly rest.

And neither can you move
forward.

The seven mountains were built
to contain this truth.
But now, the source is awakening
— and so is Kagegami.

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Renjiro clenched his fist.

Then what is Kagegami...

Can it be stopped?

The Monk looked at them.

That is a question
only you can answer.

Renjiro was pulled into a memory —
Kirisame, the day everything
changed.



You must survive,
Renjiro.

No...!

He saw it again —
Lord Takamasa's final order.
But this time, the memory
felt different.



Renjiro saw the faces of the soldiers who never returned.

I couldn't save you...
I'm sorry...

Their voices were not blaming him.
They were grateful —
for being remembered.

Akari was pulled into her own memories — her village, her family, her childhood.



Akari...

Why did you leave us...?

I wanted to protect you...
I didn't want you to suffer...

Their voices were filled with love,
not anger. But the pain was still real.

Akari fell to her knees,
overwhelmed by the memories.

I miss you so much...

I should have stayed...

No...
I can't stay here...

But deep inside, she knew —
these were memories, not a present
she could return to.

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The Nameless Monk revealed more of the truth.

In the beginning, the Keepers preserved memories to honor the dead.

But over time, they learned to alter them — to reshape regrets, to create new voices.

That is how Kagegami was born — from the accumulation of distorted memories.

What began as a way to remember became a way to control.

Centuries of memories had merged into a single existence.

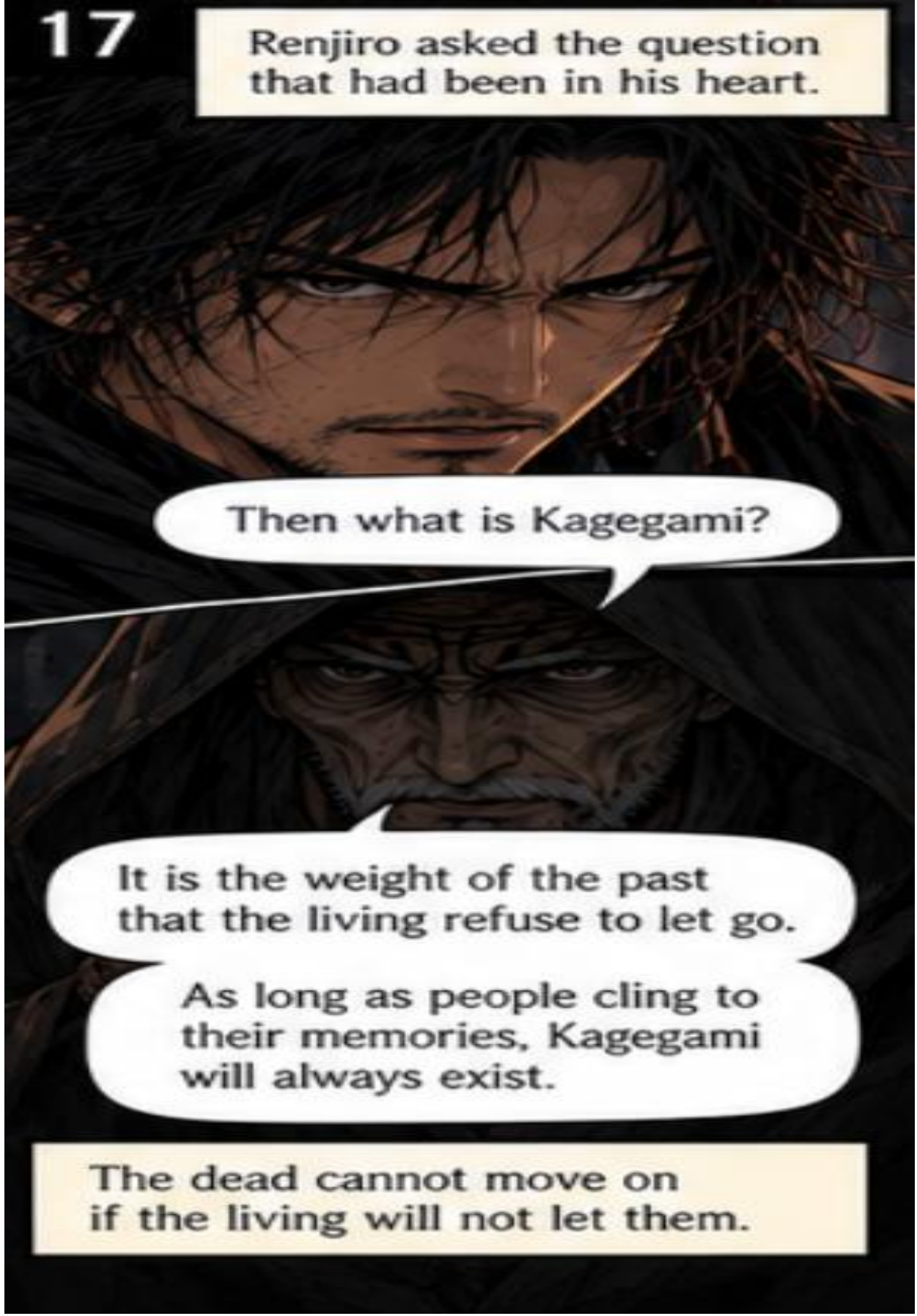


Kagegami...

It is not a person.
It is everything people
refused to let disappear.

The pain, the regrets, the hatred,
the love — all trapped, all feeding
one another.

Renjiro asked the question
that had been in his heart.



Then what is Kagegami?

It is the weight of the past
that the living refuse to let go.

As long as people cling to
their memories, Kagegami
will always exist.

The dead cannot move on
if the living will not let them.

Akari looked at the faces around her — people from her village, friends, even her younger self.



You all are still here...

But I cannot stay in
the past forever.

I will carry you with me...
not as a burden, but as a part of who
I am.



I don't need to be forgiven
by the past.

I need to stop being
controlled by it.



Mizukage was never
just a weapon...

It was a reminder —
to keep moving forward.

The voice I should listen to...
is my own.

As the truth spread, the world of memories began to tremble.



The final choice awaits...

Keep the gateway open,
and the voices will remain forever.
Or close it, and let them finally rest.

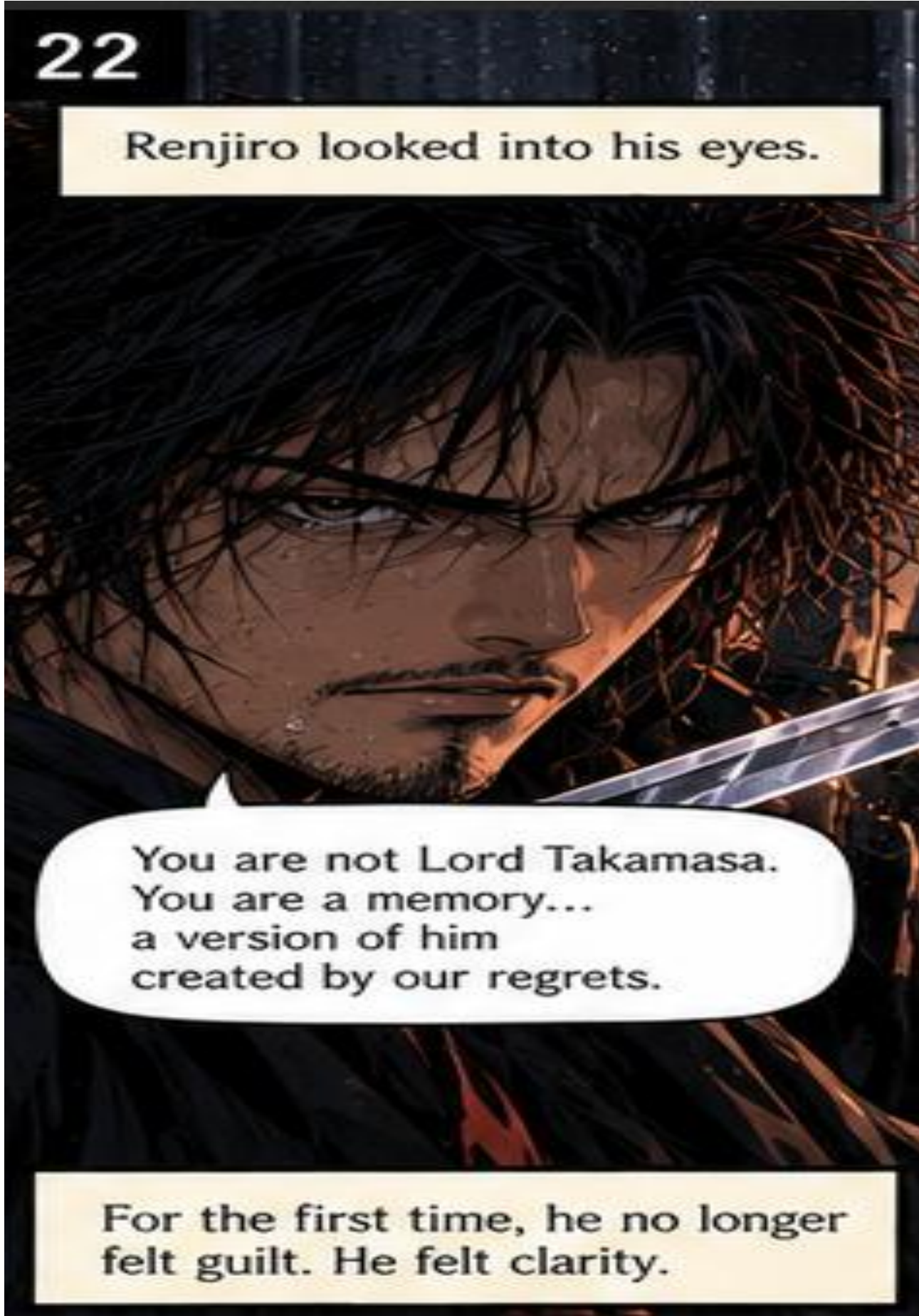


Kagegami finally took form —
not as a monster, but as someone
Renjiro knew well.

Renjiro...
Have you finally
come back?

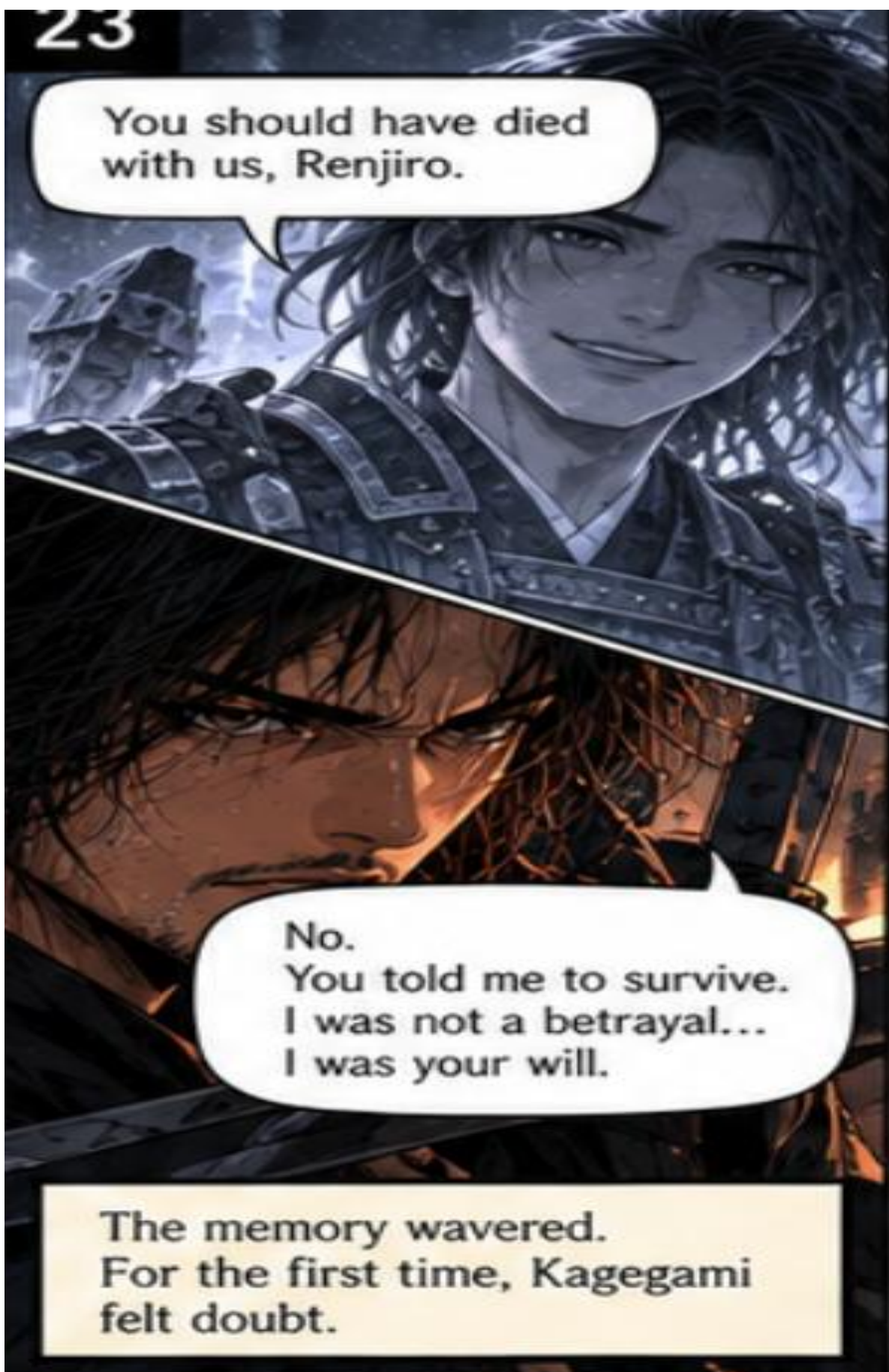
It wore the face of
Lord Takamasa.
The voice was the same.
But something felt wrong.

Renjiro looked into his eyes.



You are not Lord Takamasa.
You are a memory...
a version of him
created by our regrets.

For the first time, he no longer
felt guilt. He felt clarity.



You should have died
with us, Renjiro.

No.
You told me to survive.
I was not a betrayal...
I was your will.

The memory wavered.
For the first time, Kagegami
felt doubt.

A manga-style illustration of a young woman with long, dark, wavy hair and a red ribbon tied around it. She is looking upwards with a tearful expression. In the background, a crowd of children's faces is visible, some smiling and some looking sad. The scene is set against a dark, stormy background with lightning.

Akari faced her own past —
her family, her village,
everyone she had lost.

Why did you leave us...?

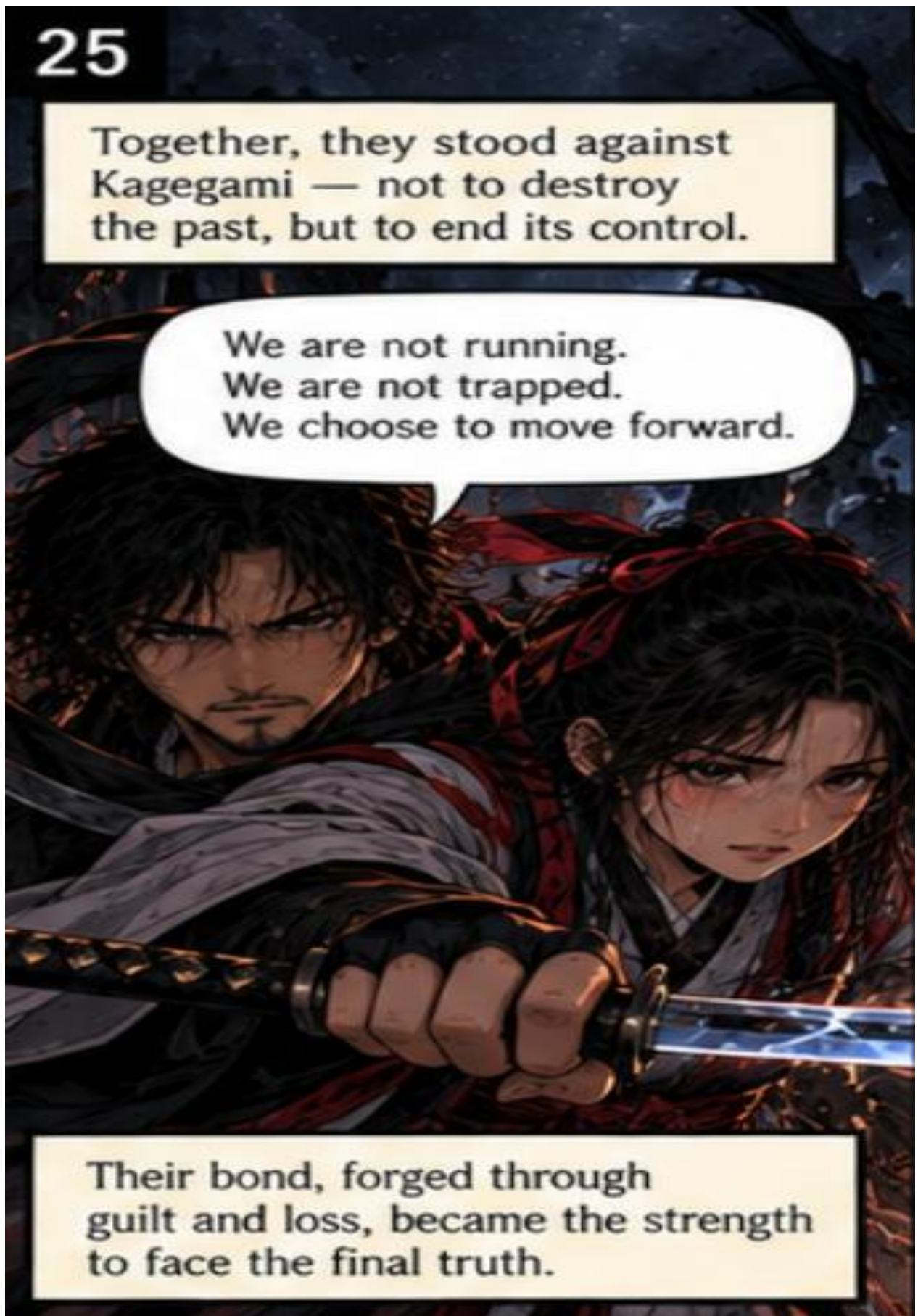
I wanted to protect you...
I'm sorry I couldn't stay.

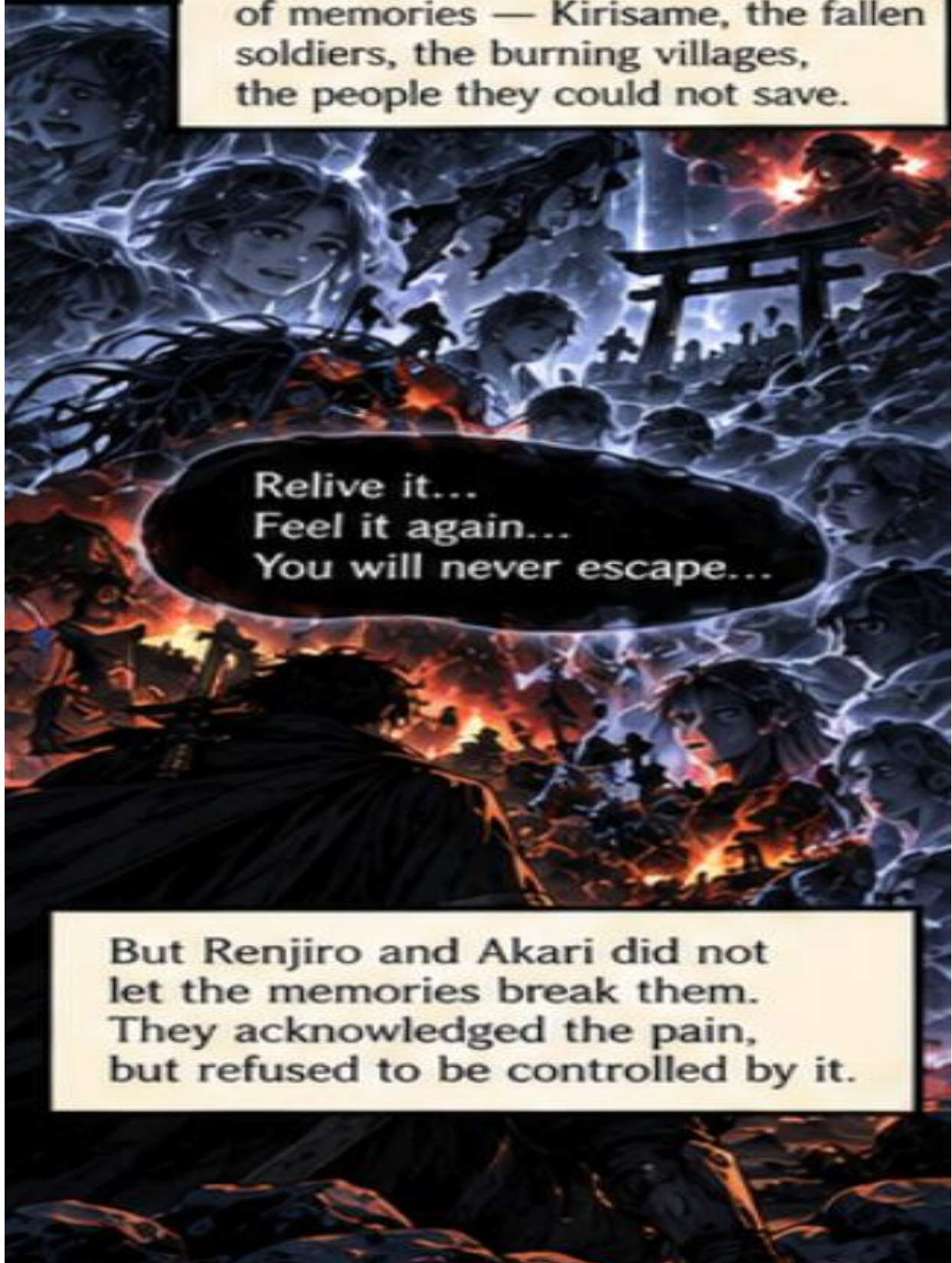
But then she understood —
their voices were not blaming her.
They were thanking her.

Together, they stood against Kagegami — not to destroy the past, but to end its control.

We are not running.
We are not trapped.
We choose to move forward.

Their bond, forged through guilt and loss, became the strength to face the final truth.





Kagegami unleashed waves of memories — Kirisame, the fallen soldiers, the burning villages, the people they could not save.

Relive it...
Feel it again...
You will never escape...

But Renjiro and Akari did not let the memories break them. They acknowledged the pain, but refused to be controlled by it.

The seven symbols began to shatter, releasing the stored voices into the sky.

No...!
You cannot let go!
They must remain!

Kagegami's true form emerged —
a being made of countless voices,
memories, and unfulfilled regrets.
It fought to keep the past alive.

Renjiro raised Mizukage one last time.

This is not a sword
to fight the past...

It is a sword
to release it.

With a single strike,
he cut through the source —
not the memories, but the chains
that bound them.

As the source broke,
the voices began to fade.

Renjiro...

Live.

That was the final voice.
Then, silence.

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The gateway closed.
The world of memories returned
to silence.

It's over...

No.
It's a new beginning.

The past is no longer gone —
but it no longer holds us.
We can finally live.

Renjiro stood before the fading source — the last remnants of countless voices.

Thank you...
for everything.

He didn't fight anymore.
He let go.
And in letting go,
he set them free.



Akari closed her eyes and whispered to the voices that once held her.

I'm sorry I couldn't stay...

But thank you
for loving me...

I will live
from now on...

The faces faded, one by one.
Not in anger, but in peace.



Lord Takamasa's final voice
reached Renjiro — clear,
calm, and free from regret.

You did well, Renjiro.
Live.
That is enough.

...I will.

For the first time,
the voice brought no pain.
Only gratitude.

With a single light, the source shattered — and the seven symbols rose into the sky.



The voices dispersed into the sky, returning to the cycle. The mountains grew silent. The world was free.

Renjiro and Akari walked back
as the sun rose over the horizon.

It's over.

Yes.
But now...
we can finally live.

They were no longer carrying
the past.
They were building the future.

Renjiro returned to Kagamori months later.

Did you find what was speaking?

Yes.

What was it?

The past.

Is it gone?

No...
But it doesn't
control us anymore.

The village was alive again.
People spoke, children laughed.
The bell rang — and nothing
unusual happened.

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Years later, Renjiro and Akari lived a quiet life near the temple.

Do you still hear them?

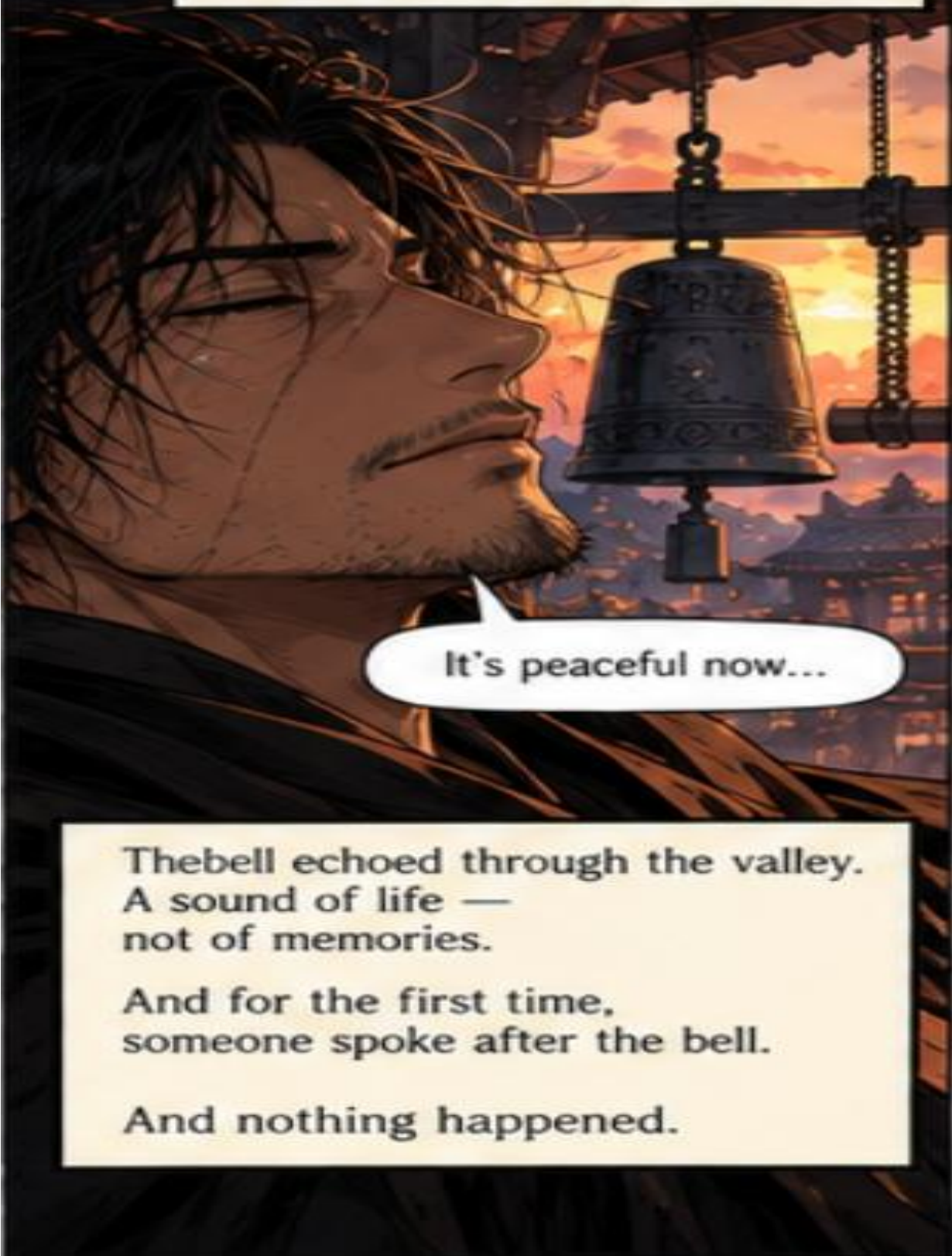
No.

Good.

Yes.

They didn't forget.
They simply learned to live
without being bound by it.

One evening, as the temple bell rang, Renjiro closed his eyes.



It's peaceful now...

The bell echoed through the valley.
A sound of life —
not of memories.

And for the first time,
someone spoke after the bell.

And nothing happened.

Renjiro and Akari looked
across the mountains one last time.

Do you regret it?

No.

Me neither.

Then it was worth it.

The seven mountains were just
mountains now.
No symbols. No voices.
Just the world, as it should be.

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And so, the story ends.
But the voices will always live
in those who choose to remember
— without being trapped by them.

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KAGE NO KOE

— 影の声 —

THE VOICE OF THE SHADOW

SOME VOICES FADE.
BUT WHAT TRULY MATTERS...
LIVES ON.

THE END